

Project Astitva

Executive Summary

Project Astitva was initiated by Upekkha as an exploratory educational initiative to understand how non-profit, volunteer-led interventions can support students in public and NGO-run schools beyond core academics. Pivoting from food distribution to education was a step aimed at learning how to create a sustainable, long-term impact that can multiply through systems.

The project was framed to be a six-week initiative, including outreach to Government schools and NGO-led learning centres for collaborations. The first step was data collection, where structured surveys were created by the R&D team, volunteer training sessions were conducted in an online format, and volunteer teams were sent to 4 institutions for data collection.

Post the data collection, final lectures were conducted at Ram Krishna Math over the course of 4 weeks (4 Sundays). The syllabus was prepared by the R&D team based on the data collection for the first lecture, post which, depending on inputs from the volunteers, future lecture plans were prepared during the week and delivered on the weekends. Each step of the project was documented by both the volunteers and members to understand difficulties and challenges.

The report is presented in 4 sections, each section covering and detailing methodologies, outcomes, challenges, assumptions, constraints, and learnings. At the end, the report paves way for further activities to be conducted in the upcoming year.

Section 1: Outreach

Overview

The outreach phase focused on identifying and engaging suitable government schools and NGOs for the pilot implementation of Project Astitva. Volunteers initiated contact with institutions, coordinated permissions, and acted as the primary point of communication between the organization and schools.

Process

Outreach teams worked on school databases, mapped schools and NGOs, and reached out through calls and/or. Emphasis was placed on building trust with school authorities, understanding institutional constraints, and assessing basic feasibility for collaboration.

Key Challenges

- Variability in response and cooperation levels across institutions
- Time and logistical constraints for school staff
- Delays in permissions and scheduling
- Limited clarity in some institutions regarding external collaborations
- Communication gaps in scope and expectations.

Learnings

The outreach phase emphasized the importance of selecting the right institutions, establishing structured engagement protocols, achieving early stakeholder alignment, and maintaining clear communication regarding scope and expectations. Relationship-building emerged as a critical prerequisite for successful field interventions.

More work is needed on identifying the right institutions for collaborations satisfying the constraints of distance, need of children, expectations from the institutions.

Section 2: Data collection and Need Assessments.

Overview

Data collection aimed to understand student needs, learning gaps, exposure levels, and contextual challenges in order to design effective interventions. This phase formed the foundation for all subsequent program decisions. The visits aimed to bridge classroom learning with real-world application by understanding how learning centres/Schools function on the ground. The focus was on observing programs, collecting data, assessing student needs, and evaluating the impact of various institutions on marginalized communities. 4 volunteer teams were sent to different locations for the data collection. The locations include - Seva Sanstha, Deep Griha Society, Purnakuti NGO, and Ram Krishna Math.

Nature of Field Engagement

Engagement methods included survey-based data collection, informal student interactions, discussions with teachers and staff, and observation-based assessment. In several cases, engagement was adapted due to age diversity, language constraints, holidays, or limited student availability, leading to greater reliance on staff interactions and observations.

The data was collected through Google Forms. Two forms were circulated among the four volunteer teams, one for students and one for teachers. The survey preparation was done by the R&D team.

Volunteer Preparation

Volunteers were briefed on ethical data collection, conversational survey methods, and sensitivity while interacting with students and educators. Emphasis was placed on listening, observation, and adaptability rather than rigid questionnaires. The volunteer training sessions were conducted in online mode with each volunteer team before the visit.

Key Observations

a) Student-level Observations

Learning levels varied widely and often did not align with grade levels, highlighting the importance of individual standing. Students were generally energetic, curious, and socially active, with younger students displaying higher curiosity. Many struggled to

articulate needs and aspirations clearly. Language comfort was strongest in Marathi and Hindi, with limited English proficiency affecting communication. A significant aspirations-awareness gap was observed, driven by limited exposure to career options. Participation patterns varied, with some students highly competitive and others passively engaged.

b) Classroom & Infrastructure Observations

Classrooms and learning spaces were generally adequate, safe, and well-lit, with access to basic resources such as books and boards. Mixed-grade teaching was common, affecting uniform comprehension. Noise and distractions were present but manageable. Access to technology was limited, and disparities between NGO facilities and home environments were noted.

c) Teacher & Staff Interactions

Teachers and staff were open, cooperative, and willing to share insights and challenges. Time constraints were common, and formal systems for comprehensive student tracking were limited. Parent involvement was generally minimal and sometimes unsupportive.

Challenges

Common challenges included –

- Long and complex surveys
- Questions not suited to younger students
- Language barriers
- Peer-influenced responses
- Limited baseline awareness
- Time constraints
- Irregular attendance
- Restrictions on survey usage in certain contexts.
- Inconsistent methods across teams
- Unclear accountability and on-ground roles
- Lack of standardized training and preparation across teams.

- Over-reliance on self-reported data
- Insufficient contextual briefing prior to visits.

Suggestions for Improvement

Effective data collection approaches included one-on-one and informal conversations, use of local languages, rapport building before data collection, observation-based assessment, group discussions, and flexible engagement methods adapted to field realities.

- Tool and Framework improvements: Simpler and shorter surveys, age-specific tools, fewer but deeper questions, observation-based indicators, and reduced assumptions about technology access.
- Process improvements: Pre-visit volunteer trainings, standardized yet flexible scripts, clear role division, buffer time for informal engagement, and improved contextual briefings.

Learnings and Conclusion

Volunteers gained practical exposure to NGO operations, field research, and data-collection, improved communication and observation skills, deeper understanding of social challenges, and greater respect for grassroots social work.

The combined field visit experience reinforced the importance of contextual understanding, flexibility, and empathy in early-stage field research. Meaningful engagement and well-designed data collection approaches are essential for generating insights that can effectively inform future program design and social interventions.

Section 3: Syllabus Design & Curriculum Framework

Overview

Based on insights from data collection, the team worked on drafting a flexible syllabus. For the 4 sessions, the drafts were prepared based on inputs from the previous field visit. The volunteer teams sent for teaching reported to the R&D department on what worked best, how much portion was covered, and what challenges were faced. Based on this information, the syllabus for next week was drafted.

Approach

The syllabus was designed to:

- be modular and adaptable,
- rely on minimal infrastructure,
- emphasize interaction over information delivery,
- align with students lived experiences.
- Be game-based.

Process

The basic format of the session listed under the syllabus included – Ice-breaker games, introduction of the topic, game/physical activity based on the topic, practice questions on blackboards, discussion sessions, information delivery, and informal conversation.

The initial session was planned around the topics of AI and Financial literacy. The session objective was later pivoted to easier topics in financial literacy, including basic mathematics, daily finances and related subjects based on the feedback from volunteers.

The syllabus was shared with the volunteer teams 2-3 days before the planned session, allowing time to raise questions and doubts if need be. The teaching material included a step-by-step method of conducting games, information to be delivered, list of practice problems, as well as Marathi words for the necessary terms for the sessions. The teaching material also mentioned if any excess material/stationery was required.

Outcomes

The process resulted in:

- structured session plans,
- clearly defined learning objectives,
- activity-based frameworks suitable for volunteer delivery.

Learnings

Curriculum drafting reinforced the need to balance standardization with contextual flexibility. The team faced difficulty in framing games relevant to the topic in a way that would complete the session objective. Clear communication between volunteer teams going on-ground and the team working on lecture preparation is extremely important to maintain smooth flow and continuity in teaching.

Section 4: Lecture Delivery & On-Ground Implementation

Overview

The final phase involved on-ground delivery of sessions by trained volunteers at Ram Krishna Math. The sessions were planned from Sunday to Sunday for 2 hours. The volunteer team was largely fixed, with a few changes as per volunteer availability. Volunteer training sessions were conducted before the visits, and lesson plans were shared beforehand.

Observations

Across all visits conducted under Project Astitva, students consistently demonstrated curiosity, enthusiasm, and a genuine interest in learning. Engagement was highest during interactive and game-based activities, where students actively participated and responded with energy. While attention during explanations was present initially, it declined after 30–40 minutes, particularly since sessions were conducted on Sundays during extended hours. This highlighted the importance of activity-driven engagement over prolonged instruction.

An important realisation during the project was that the partner institution, Ramkrishna Math, was already providing strong academic support through regular after-school education. Interactions with teachers and students revealed that academic instruction was not the primary gap. Many students were capable and interested, while others attended largely due to parental direction. Teachers further indicated that support in extracurricular exposure and access to basic resources could create a more immediate impact.

Outcomes

Learning outcomes across visits showed that students primarily required reinforcement of basic concepts rather than advanced content. While students could often recognise answers, application-based understanding was weaker. Mixed-grade classrooms further influenced learning speed and required frequent adjustment in explanation depth and pacing. Language barriers also affected delivery, especially where academic terms could not be easily translated, slowing down sessions without reducing student willingness to engage.

From a volunteer perspective, confidence in interacting with students was evident across visits. Volunteers were approachable, comfortable using Hindi, and effective in breaking the ice. However, rotating volunteer groups and gaps between visits limited continuity. Session-level coordination was often decided on the spot, resulting in confusion about content progression and contributing to a sense of operational chaos rather than a smooth learning flow.

Challenges

- Time constraints within school schedules
- Mixed-age classrooms
- Varying language proficiency
- Need for greater continuity in the session plan
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Learnings

These observations highlighted a central learning of Project Astitva: meaningful intervention requires strong alignment between planning assumptions and on-ground realities. While adaptability helped manage challenges during sessions, clearer audience targeting and pre-visit preparation are essential for improving effectiveness.

Conclusion & Way Forward

Based on the learnings from Project Astitva, the organization is consciously shifting its approach from direct, session-based educational interventions to a research-driven, systems-level mode.

While on-ground teaching helped us understand student needs and school realities, it also highlighted a key limitation: institution-specific solutions, though effective locally, are difficult to scale sustainably across public education systems.

Going forward, the focus of the project will pivot towards understanding gaps across Public Schools in Pune. The team will undertake structured research to identify common recurring gaps across public educational institutions in Pune. Instead of delivering education directly, the initiative will focus on designing diagnostic frameworks to assess school-level needs, measurement tools for engagement, exposure, and non-core learning outcomes, and low-cost, replicable models that can be adapted across multiple schools.

As a student-led and volunteer-driven organization, the organization does not position itself as a formal education provider. Instead, its role will be that of:

- A research and insight partner
- A framework and tool developer
- A bridge between ground realities and policy conversations.

This shift allows the work to remain scalable, sustainable, and aligned with long-term impact, without over-reliance on continuous on-ground delivery.

Closing Note

Project Astitva marked the beginning of this journey. The next phase focuses on depth over breadth, systems over sessions, and evidence over assumptions, with the goal of contributing meaningfully to the improvement of public education at scale.